

Response to editorial requests

We thank the editorial office for the detailed checklist of policy and formatting requests. Below we address each request in turn, indicating where in the manuscript, the Supplementary Information, or the submitted files the corresponding change has been made. As these are editorial and policy items rather than scientific points, our replies focus on what was done and where.

Source data

All source data, that is, the numerical results underlying the graphs and charts presented in the main figures, are mandatory and must be made available as Supplementary Data or via a generalist repository.

Reply: The numerical source data underlying every main-text figure are included in the Zenodo archive (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.17250038). We have added a sentence to the Data availability section stating explicitly that the archive contains the source data from which the graphs and charts are produced.

Display items

When scaled to fit the article template, text and detail in Figures 1, 4–6 and the Extended Data figures might be too small to be readable. Please ensure the figures are large enough.

Reply: We have enlarged the display items. Figure 1 is now set at full text width. The figures produced from data have been regenerated with larger fonts: the figure-generation notebooks now expose a single font-scaling control so that all text in every panel is enlarged uniformly, and the figures were re-exported accordingly. The Supplementary code listing has also been enlarged.

Please use different labels for the display items in the Supplementary Information (e.g. Supplementary Figure X), to avoid confusion with main article display items.

Reply: All Supplementary display items are now labelled “Supplementary Figure N” and “Supplementary Table N”, and the main-text references to them have been updated accordingly.

Please make sure that the legends of all figures can be understood without needing to refer to the main text; any abbreviations, symbols or colours must be defined in the associated legends. We notice that Figure 4 and Figure 5 panels A–E are not defined in the legend.

Reply: Every figure legend now defines each panel (a–e) in full, including the figures that previously read “Similar to Figure X”. The colour coding of the rank-change arrows (blue, red, grey), the dagger symbol for reinforcement-learned strategies, and the other symbols and abbreviations are now defined within the legends.

Please refer explicitly to the dashed line in Figure 2d.

Reply: The legend of Figure 2d now states that the brown dashed line marks the maximum attainable mean score of 2.9.

The number of display items should be appropriately balanced with the amount of text. Please consider moving some to the Supplementary Information.

Reply: All Extended Data items have been moved into the Supplementary Information, leaving seven main-text figures.

Code availability

We notice that your code repositories do not include an explicit license. We strongly recommend that you include a valid OSI-approved license, specified in your Code Availability statement and the code repository.

Reply: The code is released under the MIT License, an Open Source Initiative approved licence. A LICENSE file has been added to the repository, and the Code availability statement now states the licence.

Please make your code citable by obtaining a DOI for the repository, add a reference item for it, and cite it in your manuscript text or Code Availability statement.

Reply: The code is archived together with the data in Zenodo with a permanent DOI (10.5281/zenodo.17250038). The Code availability statement now cites this archive, which is included as a reference item in the bibliography, and describes it as the citable record of the exact version used in this study.

Figures

Please upload your main Figures (1–7) as individual files, one file per figure, titled “Figure XX”, in an accepted format, with no embedded captions or extra text.

Reply: Figures 1–7 are supplied as individual PDF files named “Figure_1.pdf” through “Figure_7.pdf”. Each file contains only the figure, with all panels together; the captions are not embedded in the files.

Please ensure that all main text figure captions (1–7) are grouped together at the end of your main manuscript file.

Reply: All seven figure captions are now grouped together at the end of the manuscript file, after the references, with one figure per page.

Extended Data

We see that you have submitted Extended Data items, which we do not support. Please include these items as part of the combined Supplementary Information PDF. Large datasets must be supplied as Supplementary Data files.

Reply: The Extended Data section has been removed. Its three tables and four figures are now part of the combined Supplementary Information as Supplementary Tables 1–5 and Supplementary Figures 1–5, and the underlying large datasets are available in the Zenodo archive.

Author information

Please ensure that each affiliation contains the institution name, city, and country. Currently the city name is missing in affiliations 1, 3 and 4.

Reply: Each affiliation now lists the institution, city, and country.

Funding

Any relevant funding should be declared in a separate section entitled “Funding”.

Reply: We have added a separate “Funding” section, which states that the work was not supported by any funding grants.

Statistics

Wherever statistics have been derived, the legend needs to provide and define the n number as a precise value. This information is missing in the legend of Figure 2d.

Reply: The legend of Figure 2d now states that the distributions are taken over $n = 25,000$ independent tournament repetitions.

Please note that the error bars need to be defined in the legend of Figure 2d.

Reply: The legend of Figure 2d now defines the markers: the orange marker is the mean score and the vertical orange bars span the extrema (minimum to maximum) of the distribution over the repetitions.

Please indicate the statistical test used for data analysis, whether it was one-sided or two-sided, and whether adjustments were made for multiple comparisons, in the legend of Extended Data Figure 2a.

Reply: Panel a of that figure (now Supplementary Figure 2) presents an ordinary least squares linear regression; the reported R^2 values are coefficients of determination. We have added a sentence to the legend stating that no significance tests or multiple-comparison adjustments were applied.

Supplementary Information

Please rename all the figures and tables in the Supplementary Information file as “Supplementary figure/table XX”.

Reply: All Supplementary figures and tables are now labelled in this form.

Please ensure that at least one item in the Supplementary Information PDF is cited in the main text.

Reply: The main text cites numerous Supplementary items, including Supplementary Sections S1, S4, S5, S7, S8 and S10, Supplementary Tables 1–5, and Supplementary Figures 1–5.

Main text structure

The paper should be structured as an Introduction (with the final paragraph summarising the major findings), a Results section with a single layer of sub-headings (the first appearing immediately after the Results heading), a Discussion section without sub-headings, and a Methods section thereafter.

Reply: We have restructured the manuscript accordingly. The opening section is now “Introduction”, and its final paragraph lists the three contributions of the work. “Results” uses a single layer of sub-headings, the first of which (“Reviving the tournament”) appears immediately after the heading. We removed the bold paragraph lead-ins that previously acted as a second layer of headings. “Discussion” contains no sub-headings, and “Methods” follows it.

Tables

Data in tables must be free from bold or italic formatting unless this has been clearly defined in a footnote.

Reply: The data cells of all tables are free from bold and italic formatting.

Footnotes

We see that your manuscript contains footnotes, which are not compatible with our style. Please incorporate this text into the main text or the Supplementary Information.

Reply: The single footnote has been removed; its content (the archival URL and access date) is now given inline in the Introduction.

Files

The main article file was submitted in PDF format, which we are unable to accept. Please resubmit in DOC, DOCX or LaTeX format, with a compiled PDF and the bibliography data.

Reply: The manuscript is provided in LaTeX, together with a compiled PDF and the bibliography. The article, the Supplementary Information, the bibliography, and the bibliography style now reside in a single directory so that the sources compile without modification.